

winner of the ISL Shield and ISL Cup) — all started their senior professional careers in Shillong despite hailing from other states.

Beyond Lajong, the city remains a bustling hub of lower-division domestic football, with the Meghalaya State League and the Shillong Premier League (SPL) having played here regularly since 2017.

The SPL, the sixth division of Indian football, began in 2010 and serves as a feeder for successive higher divisions, starting with the State League. The structure has produced multiple stars like Tlang, who won the SPL in 2016 and went on to help NorthEast United to its first-ever trophy in 2024.

Padam Chhetri, SPL's best goalkeeper in 2019, helped Mohammedan Sporting win the I-League four years later and secure promotion into the ISL. The State now has six players competing in India's top flight league.

At the state level, Meghalaya reached the final of the National Junior Championship (Mir Iqbal Hussain Trophy) three times in the last five editions, winning it twice. It also reached the Santosh Trophy final (Senior Men's Nationals) for the first time in 2023.

"It's an economy that we are trying to create out of music and sports. It is like a passion for us and it makes sense to really push on it," Sangma added.

However, Meghalaya's presence in the national men's team remains quite limited.

In the last two international windows, 17 players were called up from the northeast — nine from Mizoram, seven from Manipur, and only one from Sikkim.

Rocus Lamare and Eugeneson Lyngdoh remain the only prominent players from the state to have played for India, winning the SAFF Championship in 2011 and 2015, respectively.

"When you plant a mango sapling, it takes time for it to grow into a tree and bear fruit. Similarly, in what we are doing today, it's not that we get all the fruits at once. It takes time," Sangma opined.



Call of duty: Action from a friendly between India and Maldives at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium in Shillong. Meghalaya's presence in the national men's team remains quite limited. AIFF

"If you look at the ecosystem that we are creating and the goals that we have set for ourselves, the investments and the commitment that we are making towards sports and football are in the right direction."

The state is investing over ₹1,200 crore in building a new football stadium in Mawkhonu and 50 new football turfs by 2028, 25 of which are already under construction.

"We want to target about 25,000 children through our grassroots programme by 2029," Sangma added.

This year, Shillong hosted an ISL game for the first time, with NorthEast United playing three of its home games here, as well as a play-off against Jamshedpur FC, at the renovated Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, also known as Polo Ground.

It also became home to the men's national team last month, for a friendly against the Maldives on March 19, and a draw with Bangladesh in the AFC Asian Cup qualifier six days later.

"It is the first time we are playing here, but I have worked with a lot of coaches and players from here. I



Domestic football hierarchy in Meghalaya

ISL

I-League

I-League 2

I-League 3

Meghalaya State League

Shillong Premier League

knew it's a very nice place," Manolo Marquez, India's head coach, said before the Maldives game.

Eight major matches — Indian top division and international — have been played here since the stadium's renovation in 2024, with the venue averaging at least 86 per cent capacity.

The Asian Cup qualifier saw an attendance of 14,952 — just 148 short of a full-house. Unlike at a few venues in India, there were no schoolchildren dragged into the stadium to fill up seats.

For music, Shillong is already a capital. Can it now become one for Indian football?